DEFENCE | National Security

BADGE OF COURAGE: Soldiers, robots, borders, AI. The challenge of new-generation warfare and the idea of India in uniform

GENERAL MANOJ PANDE *Chief of the Army Staff*

FORWARD MARCHES

To embrace the newest technological changes that are sweeping war doctrines and revolutionising decades-old strategies, while keeping a balance with the old—General Manoj Pande , Chief of the Army Staff, is clear on the path ahead for the Indian Army. At this crucial time, it's significant that the army is led by Gen. Pande—the first engineer ever (The Bombay Sappers) to hold the post. Gen. Pande believes the Ukraine conflict holds many lessons—across strategic, operational and tactical domains. He said the Indian military is taking measures to modernise by adopting niche technology like Artificial Intelligence (AI) and blockchain that can be a game-changer in warfare and harnessing Indian start-ups, indigenous industry and academia to reach that goal.

The army chief said the borders with Pakistan and China remain 'stable', but all developments are being closely monitored. While the Indian military is at a transformational phase where it's working on increasing its operational efficiency, Gen. Pande said it is maintaining a high level of operational readiness. He also noted the growing acquisition of indigenous hardware amidst India's high arms imports. The COAS said while the Agnipath recruitment scheme is unique, the army will keep an ear out for feedback and bring about constructive changes. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The overall situation on the LAC is stable. But there is no reduction of deployment by China close to the border
- Notwithstanding the political instability and economic downturn in Pakistan, there's no significant reduction in terror infrastructure
- The Ukraine conflict shows the importance of small teams, including citizen warriors and smaller platforms like drones
- The Indian military must be weaned from imports from nations like the US, Russia and France
- It's important for a soldier to be multi-skilled
- Agniveer is a win-win scheme for the military, society and country

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